

Champaign, Illinois, 61820
February 18, 2025

Mary Durstock
Ainsworth Lab
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign
South Farms, Urbana-Champaign, IL

Dear Ms. Durstock,

I am writing to express my interest in the research position with the Ainsworth Lab. I am a senior majoring in statistics with a minor in mathematics at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign and will be continuing my studies in graduate school this fall. I am eager to apply my analytical skills and research experience to agricultural studies focused on climate change. While my background is not in crop sciences, my experience in data collection, research, and working in dynamic environments makes me well-suited for this role.

My research background includes experience in data science and machine learning applications, where I have worked with large datasets to extract meaningful insights. As a machine learning intern team leader, I have conducted data collection, processing, and statistical analysis on high-dimensional data, ensuring accuracy and reproducibility, which are essential skills in field research. Additionally, my role as a consultant at Illinois Business Consulting has strengthened my ability to work collaboratively, solve complex problems, and adapt quickly to new research areas.

Beyond technical skills, I am comfortable working in hands-on environments and adapting to new challenges. My military service in the Korean Augmentation to the United States Army required discipline, resilience, and the ability to perform tasks in physically demanding conditions. These experiences make me confident in my ability to work outdoors in variable weather conditions, perform field maintenance tasks, and follow precise data collection protocols at the SoyFACE facility.

I am excited about the opportunity to apply my problem-solving skills to agricultural research and learn more about the intersection of climate science and data analysis. Thank you for your time and consideration. I look forward to the opportunity to contribute to your team and discuss how my skills align with this role.

Sincerely,

Sangjun Ko
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